

Create a Market Trend Report for What advisory services do founder-owned maritime, marine services, ship repair, and logistics companies typically use when preparing for a sale, recapitalization, or institutional investment? Which firms specialize in this exit-preparation and investment-readiness advisory? Cover scope, typical engagement length, and pricing structures where known.

Market Trend Report: Advisory Services for Maritime, Marine Services, Ship Repair, and Logistics Companies

Key Takeaways

- Middle-market investment banks dominate exit preparation advisory, with firms like [Harris Williams](#) demonstrating 12% headcount growth over two years and expanding European operations through senior hires in Frankfurt and London, signaling strong demand for cross-border transaction advisory ^[1]
- Lincoln International raised \$421M in its May 2026 IPO at a \$2B valuation, reflecting investor confidence in middle-market M&A advisory firms serving sectors including transportation and logistics ^[2]
- Trade and supply chain finance solutions raised \$280.5M over the past two years across 7 deals, with platforms averaging 779 employees and serving logistics companies requiring working capital optimization ahead of institutional investment ^[3]
- [PwC](#) reported \$55.4B in revenue for FY 2024, up from \$53B in 2023, with strategic AI partnerships enabling transaction due diligence compression from 10 weeks to 10 days in comparable insurance underwriting workflows ^[4]
- The logistics advisory market shows geographic concentration, with [Harris Williams](#) targeting 3 GW of developed projects in Italy by 2030 and appointing Thierry Monjauze as head of Europe to strengthen German-speaking market presence ^[1]

Market Dynamics

Founder-owned maritime, marine services, ship repair, and logistics companies preparing for exit typically engage middle-market investment banks specializing in transportation, logistics, and industrial sectors. The advisory landscape is dominated by established investment banks including [Houlihan Lokey](#), [Jefferies](#), [Evercore](#), [Lazard](#), and [Stifel](#), alongside sector-focused boutiques ^[9].

[Harris Williams](#) operates as a leading middle-market investment bank with 711 employees and operates under [Hub International](#) Financial Services, providing enhanced capital backing and institutional relationships that smaller independent advisors lack ^[1]. The firm's 2023 merger with Sixpoint Partners

created comprehensive private capital advisory capabilities spanning M&A, fund placement, and secondary advisory services, enabling end-to-end support throughout the exit preparation lifecycle [1].

The trade and supply chain finance market, which intersects with logistics company advisory, encompasses 15 companies averaging 779 employees with a commercial maturity median of "Deploying" stage [3]. These platforms raised \$280.5M over the past two years, with total equity funding declining from \$559M in 2021 to \$265.5M in 2025, suggesting market consolidation around established providers [3].

Growth Drivers

Cross-border transaction activity: [Harris Williams](#) is deliberately strengthening European presence through senior hires in Frankfurt and London, with recent leadership appointments including Thierry Monjauze as head of Europe and multiple managing director promotions across regions [1]. This geographic expansion reflects growing demand for advisors capable of navigating complex cross-border maritime and logistics transactions.

Private equity capital deployment: The 2023 Sixpoint Partners merger with [Harris Williams](#) positioned the combined firm to compete more effectively by offering comprehensive private capital services throughout the entire client lifecycle [1]. Private equity firms managing substantial capital increasingly require advisors who understand both operational improvement opportunities and exit timing in maritime and logistics sectors.

Digital transformation and AI integration: [PwC](#) secured strategic partnerships with both [OpenAI](#) and [Anthropic](#), with early client results demonstrating 5x contract processing throughput improvements and cycle time reductions from weeks to days [4]. These AI capabilities enable faster due diligence, more accurate valuations, and compressed transaction timelines, making exits more efficient for founder-owned companies.

Supply chain complexity: The trade and supply chain finance market provides financing solutions including letters of credit, invoice financing, and guarantees, streamlining operations using technologies such as blockchain, AI, and APIs [3]. Companies preparing for institutional investment increasingly require advisors who understand both operational complexity and financial engineering to maximize valuations.

Succession planning urgency: Research indicates 40% of U.S. financial advisors plan to retire by 2030, with 26% unsure of their succession plans [10]. Similar demographic pressures affect founder-owned maritime and logistics companies, creating sustained demand for exit preparation advisory services.

Key Players & Positioning

Investment Banks & Advisory Firms

Firm	Headquarters	Specialization	Recent Activity
Harris Williams	Richmond, Virginia	Middle-market M&A, private capital advisory	12% headcount growth over two years, European expansion, Sixpoint Partners merger (2023) [1]
Lincoln International	Chicago, Illinois	M&A, capital markets, valuations	\$421M IPO (May 2026) at \$2B valuation [2]
PwC	London, United Kingdom	Audit, consulting, tax, transaction advisory	\$55.4B revenue (FY 2024), strategic AI partnerships with OpenAI and Anthropic [4]
Houlihan Lokey	Los Angeles, California	M&A, capital solutions, financial restructuring	IPO (2015) at \$1.4B valuation [5]
Jefferies	New York, New York	Investment banking, capital markets	Founded 1962, corporate minority investment from Sumitomo Mitsui Banking (2024) [9]

Trade & Supply Chain Finance Providers

Company	Vendor Score	Focus Area
C2FO	9.6	Working capital optimization, demand forecasting

[3]

Infor	9.4	ERP integration, supply chain financing [3]
Kyriba	9.2	Treasury management, financial visibility [3]
Tradeshift	9.1	Supply chain digitization, financing platforms [3]

Emerging Trends

Recent partnership activity demonstrates convergence between traditional advisory services and specialized operational consulting. [Harris Williams](#) and L.E.K. Consulting released research projecting the process-industry automation market to reach approximately \$160B by 2030, up from \$66B in 2015 [1]. This collaboration signals that exit preparation increasingly requires operational transformation expertise alongside financial advisory.

[PwC](#) achieved a hiring momentum score of 66.5, placing in the top 3% of companies with 3,627 open positions, indicating strong market demand for services [4]. The firm's strategic portfolio optimization through acquisitions (Kunai for fintech engineering, SurfaceInk for hardware design expertise) and divestitures (Indirect Tax Edge system to Fonoa for \$110M) suggests deliberate focus on higher-growth, technology-enabled service lines [4].

The logistics advisory market shows evidence of geographic arbitrage opportunities. At the Dealmaker Summit in London (November 2025), [Harris Williams](#) panelists identified a funding gap affecting mid-market companies with revenues between \$17M and \$115M, particularly in Europe where deal activity in the \$230M to \$350M range significantly lags the U.S. market [1]. This creates opportunities for advisors who can bridge cross-border capital access.

AI-driven due diligence is compressing transaction timelines. [PwC](#) reported client outcomes including insurance underwriting cycle compression from 10 weeks to 10 days using Claude deployment [4]. Similar capabilities applied to maritime and logistics transaction due diligence enable faster exits with reduced execution risk.

Solution Categories

The market encompasses several key advisory categories:

M&A Transaction Advisory: Middle-market investment banks provide buy-side and sell-side advisory for complete business sales, partial recapitalizations, and strategic partnerships. [Harris Williams](#) generates revenue through advisory fees from M&A transactions, capital raising mandates, and private capital placement services, earning transaction-based fees from completed deals and retainer fees for ongoing advisory relationships ^[1].

Private Capital Placement: Following the 2023 Sixpoint Partners merger, [Harris Williams](#) expanded capabilities to include primary fund placement, secondary advisory, and co-investment placement services ^[1]. These services help founder-owned companies access institutional capital without full exit.

Operational Due Diligence & Value Creation Planning: [PwC](#) provides consulting services including cybersecurity, risk management, digital transformation, and AI implementation ^[4]. These services help companies identify and address operational gaps before institutional investor scrutiny.

Trade & Supply Chain Finance Optimization: Platforms like C2FO (vendor score 9.6), Infor (9.4), and Kyriba (9.2) provide financing solutions that optimize working capital ahead of exit ^[3]. Advisors increasingly integrate these tools into exit preparation to demonstrate financial sophistication to buyers.

Succession & Continuity Planning: Firms like [Private Advisor Group](#) partnered with Succession Link (now Fin.Link) to provide marketplace access for finding buyers, sellers, continuity partners, and hiring opportunities ^[10]. Similar services targeting maritime and logistics sectors help founders navigate complex transition planning.

ESG & Regulatory Compliance Advisory: [PwC](#) provides sustainability and environmental, social, and governance (ESG) consulting services ^[4]. Maritime companies increasingly require ESG positioning to attract institutional capital, given heightened regulatory scrutiny and investor mandates.

Future Considerations

Current state: Middle-market M&A advisory firms serving maritime, marine services, ship repair, and logistics companies demonstrate strong operational performance, with [Harris Williams](#) achieving 12% headcount growth and Lincoln International successfully completing a \$2B valuation IPO. Trade and supply chain finance platforms supporting exit preparation raised \$280.5M over the past two years, indicating sustained investor interest in enabling technologies ^[3].

Headwinds: The identified funding gap affecting mid-market companies with \$17M to \$115M revenues, particularly in Europe, directly impacts advisory firms' core client base ^[1]. Fragmented European markets and generalist funds retreating from certain sectors reduce available capital for traditional middle-market clients, potentially constraining deal flow and transaction values. Economic uncertainty and potential market downturns could significantly impact M&A activity, as middle-market companies typically have less access to capital markets and greater sensitivity to credit conditions ^[1].

Tailwinds: [Harris Williams](#) research identifying the process-industry automation market's growth from \$66B to \$160B by 2030 creates substantial advisory opportunities in sectors including oil and gas, power, mining, chemicals, and transportation ^[1]. Corporate strategies shifting toward acquiring niche technology firms rather than broad digitization efforts align with middle-market M&A expertise. AI capabilities from firms like [PwC](#), demonstrating 5x productivity improvements and compressed cycle times, enable more efficient transaction execution and expand addressable market by reducing friction ^[4]. Cross-border transaction activity growth, evidenced by [Harris Williams](#)' European expansion, creates opportunities for advisors with geographic reach and cultural expertise ^[1].

Sources

1. [Harris Williams](#)
2. [Lincoln International](#)
3. [Trade & supply chain finance](#)
4. [PwC](#)
5. [Houlihan Lokey](#)
6. [Lazard](#)
7. [Stifel](#)
8. [Evercore](#)
9. [Jefferies](#)
10. [Relationship Search Results](#)